

CAREER CONSTELLATION

A portfolio of learning design
for adult learners in the
age of emerging technology.

Master's Defense · Learning Design & Technologies

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POSITIONING

Where this portfolio comes from.

I design for the intersection of emerging technology and adult learners.

Senior Solutions Architect at NVIDIA — AI Enterprise for Higher Education and Research. Instructor at Georgia Tech's Scheller College of Business (MGT 3745, Business Programming). Five master's degrees across computer science, HCI, MBA, entrepreneurship, and — the one that frames this defense — Learning Design & Technologies.

Every artifact in this portfolio was built with the same audience in mind: working adults — faculty, engineers, students returning mid-career — who have every reason not to engage with one more new thing, and who deserve instruction that respects that.

PRACTICE

NVIDIA

AI Enterprise for Higher Ed

TEACHING

Georgia Tech

MGT 3745 — Scheller

SCHOLARSHIP

University of South Carolina

Learning Design & Technologies

If every artifact in this portfolio could only make one claim...

The adoption of emerging technology in adult learning is directly proportional to the *empathy* and *enthusiasm* of those modeling and sharing it.

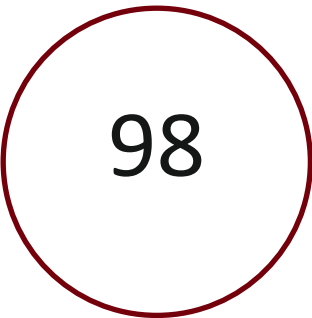
— the argument this portfolio makes, across nine courses and nine artifacts.

How to read this constellation.

THE PORTFOLIO

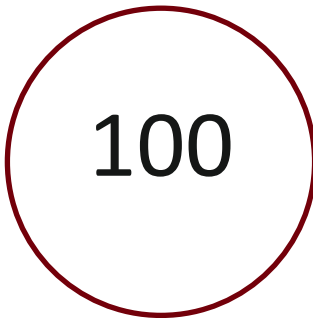
johnmcswain.github.io

Five-page site: Home · Artifacts · Presentation · Reflection · References.

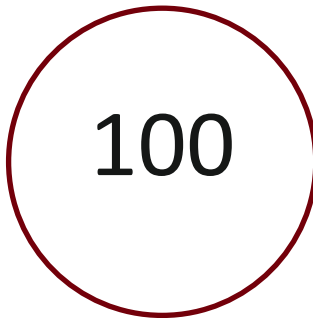


Performance

Lighthouse, April 2026



Accessibility



Best Practices

THE STANDARDS

AECT Standards 1–5

Association for Educational Communications and Technology — the field's framework for what a learning designer must demonstrate.

- 1 Content Knowledge
- 2 Content Pedagogy
- 3 Learning Environments
- 4 Professional Knowledge & Skills
- 5 Research

Content Knowledge.

1

Designers demonstrate the knowledge necessary to create, use, assess, and manage theoretical and practical applications of educational technologies educational technologies and processes.

EDET 603 · INTEGRATED MULTIMEDIA

Top Five with JavaScript

What it demonstrates.

An interactive, browser-native learning artifact built from scratch with HTML, CSS, and JavaScript — content and container designed as one.

Why it matters.

Content knowledge in this field is not abstract. It is the ability to ship the thing you're teaching people to build.

EDET 722 · EVALUATION

Formative Evaluation Plan

What it demonstrates.

A structured plan for testing instruction before it ships — identifying what to measure, to measure, how, and when to course-correct.

Why it matters.

The discipline of treating instruction as a hypothesis to be tested, not a product to be shipped.

Content Pedagogy.

2

Designers apply content pedagogy by creating instructional design products based on contemporary content and pedagogy.

EDET 703 · DESIGN MODELS

Research Lesson Plan

What it demonstrates.

A full lesson plan grounded in learning theory, with explicit objectives, assessments, and the pedagogical reasoning behind each choice.

Why it matters.

Pedagogy is not the decoration on top of content. It is the architecture that decides whether the content lands.

EDET 746 · TECH PROCUREMENT

Anthropic's Claude — Procurement & Lifecycle Plan

What it demonstrates.

A full procurement and lifecycle management plan for introducing a generative AI tool into an instructional context — with budgeting, training, and sunset and sunset criteria.

Why it matters.

Emerging technology does not become pedagogy until someone plans how it will be taught, supported, and retired.

Learning Environments.

3

Designers facilitate learning by creating, using, evaluating, and managing effective learning environments.

EDET 705/709 · ASSESSMENT

Georgia Tech Firebase — Lesson Plan Evaluation Evaluation

What it demonstrates.

A structured evaluation of a live learning environment (a Firebase workshop I taught at Georgia Tech) against lesson plan criteria.

Why it matters.

Learning environments are only as good as our willingness to evaluate our own teaching honestly. This was mine.

EDET 735 · ACCESSIBILITY

Screen Reader Final Project

What it demonstrates.

A project designed and tested for screen-reader users — accessibility treated as a treated as a design constraint from the start, not a retrofit.

Why it matters.

A learning environment that excludes even one learner is not the environment I claim it is. Accessibility is the honesty check.

Professional Knowledge & Skills.

4

Designers design, develop, implement, and evaluate technology-rich learning environments within a supportive community of practice.

EDET 722 · DEVELOPING INSTRUCTION

Developing Instruction

What it demonstrates.

End-to-end development of a technology-rich instructional sequence — from analysis through implementation.

Why it matters.

Professional practice is the full loop. Designing without implementing is theater.

EDET 755 · APPLIED PROJECT

MGT 7316 — Cloud Application Development

What it demonstrates.

A graduate-level cloud development course I taught at Georgia Tech — curriculum, curriculum, assessments, and live instruction for working professionals.

Why it matters.

The most honest evidence that a learning designer can design is a course that strangers actually complete.

Research.

5

Designers explore, evaluate, synthesize, and apply methods of inquiry to enhance learning and improve performance.

EDET 801 · RESEARCH IN ED. TECH.

Annotated Bibliography

What it demonstrates.

A curated, annotated survey of the literature on a research question central to my practice — positioning my own work within an existing conversation.

Why it matters.

Research is, first, reading well. This artifact is the reading. The next artifact is what I did with it.

EDET 793 · ADVANCED INSTRUCTIONAL DESIGN

This Portfolio & Defense

What it demonstrates.

The capstone artifact — a reflective synthesis of every prior course, mapped to AECT to AECT standards, defended in conversation with a committee.

Why it matters.

Research is not only what you publish. It is the habit of making your work legible to people who can argue with it.

Four threads run through every artifact.

1

Adult learners, always.

Every artifact assumes a learner who is tired, busy, skeptical, and capable. No artifact in this portfolio was designed for children or captive audiences.

2

Emerging technology as a subject — and a tool.

JavaScript, Firebase, Claude, cloud development, screen readers. The portfolio's content is new technology; so is the medium it's delivered through.

3

Accessibility as a design constraint.

From the screen reader project to a Lighthouse 100 on the portfolio itself — accessibility is the quality check that forces honest design.

4

Empathy and enthusiasm as transmission.

The through-line. Every artifact was built by someone who wanted the learner to succeed — and who believed the technology was worth their time. time.

If I had to leave the program with one sentence:

The success of learning design and emerging technology in instruction is *directly proportional* to the empathy and enthusiasm of those modeling and sharing it.



Empathy without enthusiasm is condescension.

Enthusiasm without empathy is noise.

Adult learners can tell the difference before you finish the first slide.

Four values I design by.

Extracted from a personal philosophy I've been writing alongside this degree, *In Spite Of* — translated into the language of the field.

I. Teach in spite of.

Adult learners show up tired, skeptical, and overbooked. The job is to design for people who have every reason not to engage — and to do it anyway.

II. Name the cost.

Every tool, framework, and method has a real price — cognitive, financial, emotional. Honest instructional design surfaces costs rather than hiding them behind enthusiasm.

III. More often than not.

Mastery in practice is not perfection. It is a genuine, honest majority. Design for the Design for the durable average — the Tuesday afternoon — not the demo. demo.

IV. Dignity before correction.

How knowledge is delivered matters as much as the knowledge itself. Empathy is not Empathy is not a soft skill. It is the transmission medium.

How these commitments show up in the work.

■ *Teach in spite of.*

The MGT 7316 cloud course — designed for working professionals juggling full-time work while learning cloud architecture.

■ *Name the cost.*

The Claude Procurement Plan — explicit about licensing, training burden, and sunset criteria. No hand-waving on price.

■ *More often than not.*

The Formative Evaluation Plan — designed for the honest majority case, not the pilot with ideal users.

■ *Dignity before correction.*

The Screen Reader project — accessibility as design, not retrofit. No learner is the exception.

WHAT CHANGED

What the LDT program actually did to my practice.

BEFORE

I taught workshops because I knew the technology.

BEFORE

Accessibility was something I added at the end.

BEFORE

Evaluation meant asking 'did they like it?'

BEFORE

I treated emerging tech as inherently interesting.

AFTER

→ I design instruction because I understand how adults change.

AFTER

→ Accessibility is the quality check I start with.

AFTER

→ Evaluation means asking 'what do they now do differently?'

AFTER

→ I treat emerging tech as something learners must be invited into.

WHAT'S NEXT

The constellation keeps growing.

DOCTORAL WORK

Active applications across three programs — extending LDT into applied research on AI-augmented adult learning.

Penn State · Texas A&M · University of Arizona

PRACTITIONER PUBLISHING

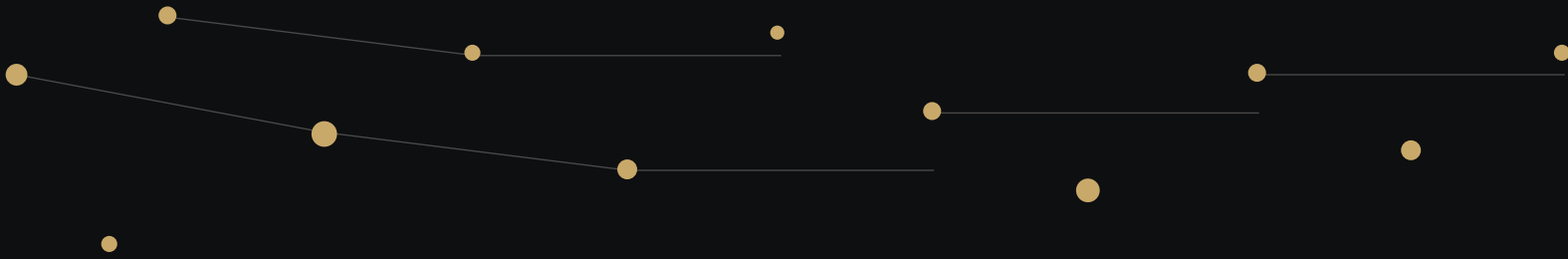
A framework for explainable ROI in technology-rich instructional decisions — from field notebook to working paper.

SSRN · InfoQ · O'Reilly proposal under review

TEACHING

Continuing MGT 3745 at Georgia Tech — redesigned around AI-era software reasoning for business students.

Scheller College of Business



A constellation is not a conclusion.

It's a way of reading what's already there —
and a starting position for wherever you go next.



Thank you.

I welcome your questions.

Portfolio and supporting documents.

Portfolio site.

[johnmcswain.github.io](#) — [Home](#) · [Artifacts](#) · [Presentation](#) · [Reflection](#) · [References](#)

Framework.

Association for Educational Communications and Technology (AECT) Standards 1–5.

Philosophical grounding.

McSwain, J. I. (2026). *In Spite Of: A Personal Philosophy*. Working manuscript.

Portfolio technologies.

[HTML](#) · [CSS](#) · [JavaScript](#) · [GitHub Pages](#) · [GitHub Actions](#) · [Google Fonts](#). Lighthouse: Performance 98, Accessibility 100, Best Practices 100.

Course artifacts (by standard).

Std. 1 — [EDET 603 Top Five with JavaScript](#) · [EDET 722 Formative Evaluation Plan](#).

Std. 2 — [EDET 703 Research Lesson Plan](#) · [EDET 746 Claude Procurement & Lifecycle Plan](#).

Std. 3 — [EDET 705/709 Georgia Tech Firebase Evaluation](#) · [EDET 735 Screen Reader Project](#).

Std. 4 — [EDET 722 Developing Instruction](#) · [EDET 755 MGT 7316 Cloud Application Development](#).

Std. 5 — [EDET 801 Annotated Bibliography](#) · [EDET 793 Capstone Portfolio & Defense](#).